

The Way of the Blue Mat

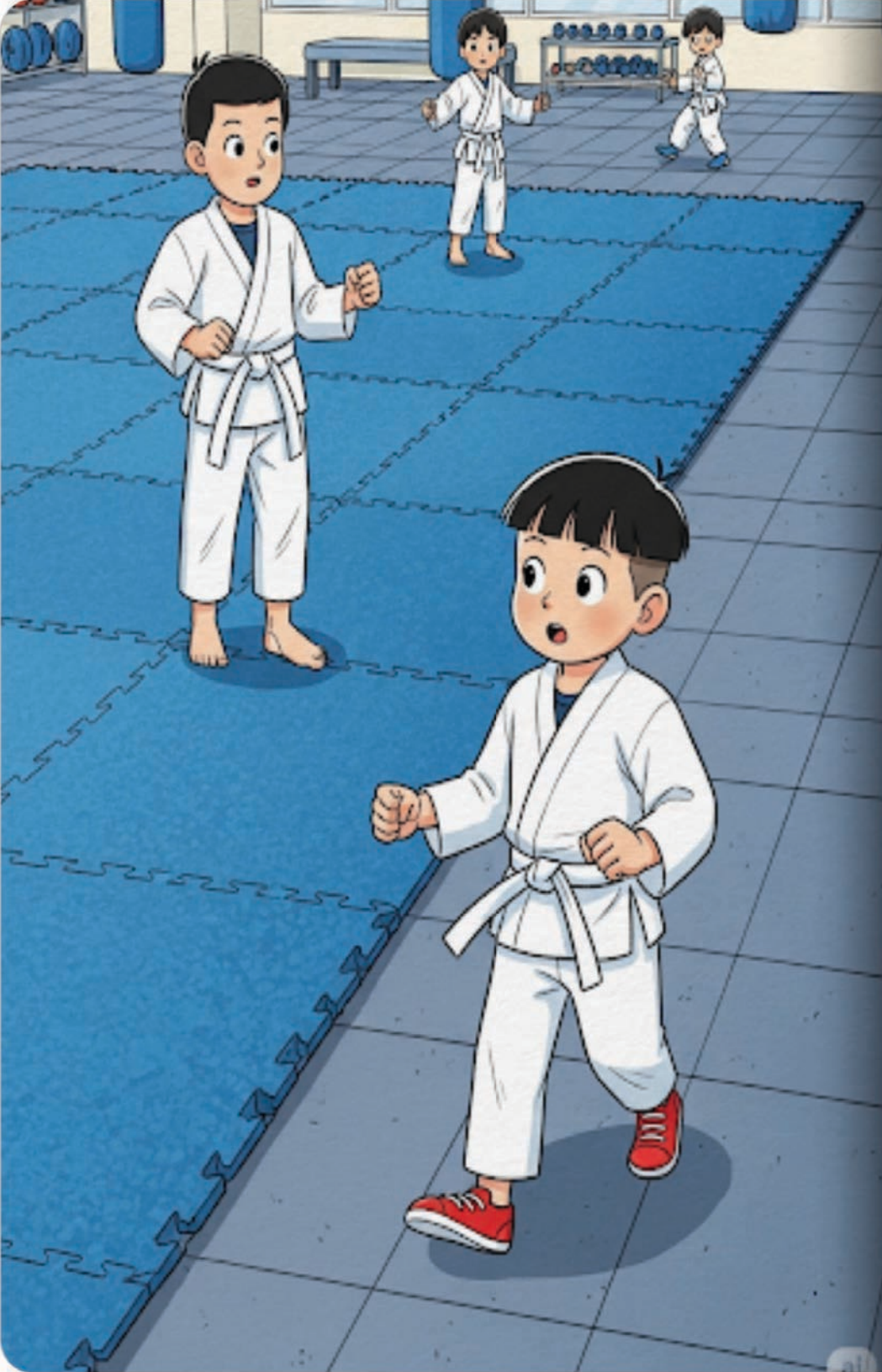
By Kaio Andrade



Kenji stood outside the heavy glass doors of the Iron Turtle Martial Arts Academy. He clutched his new white gi tightly in his arms. Through the window, he saw people rolling and tumbling on bright blue mats. It looked exciting, but his stomach felt like it was doing somersaults of its own. He took a deep breath and pushed the door open, the scent of cleaning spray and laundry detergent meeting him at the entrance.



As Kenji stepped inside, a tall woman with a kind smile and a black belt tied around her waist walked over. "Hello! You must be Kenji," she said. Kenji started to say 'Hi,' but then he remembered what his dad told him. He stood up straight and gave a polite nod. "Hello, Coach Elara. I'm ready to learn." Coach Elara beamed. "That's the spirit! In this gym, we treat everyone with respect, from the coaches to your training partners."



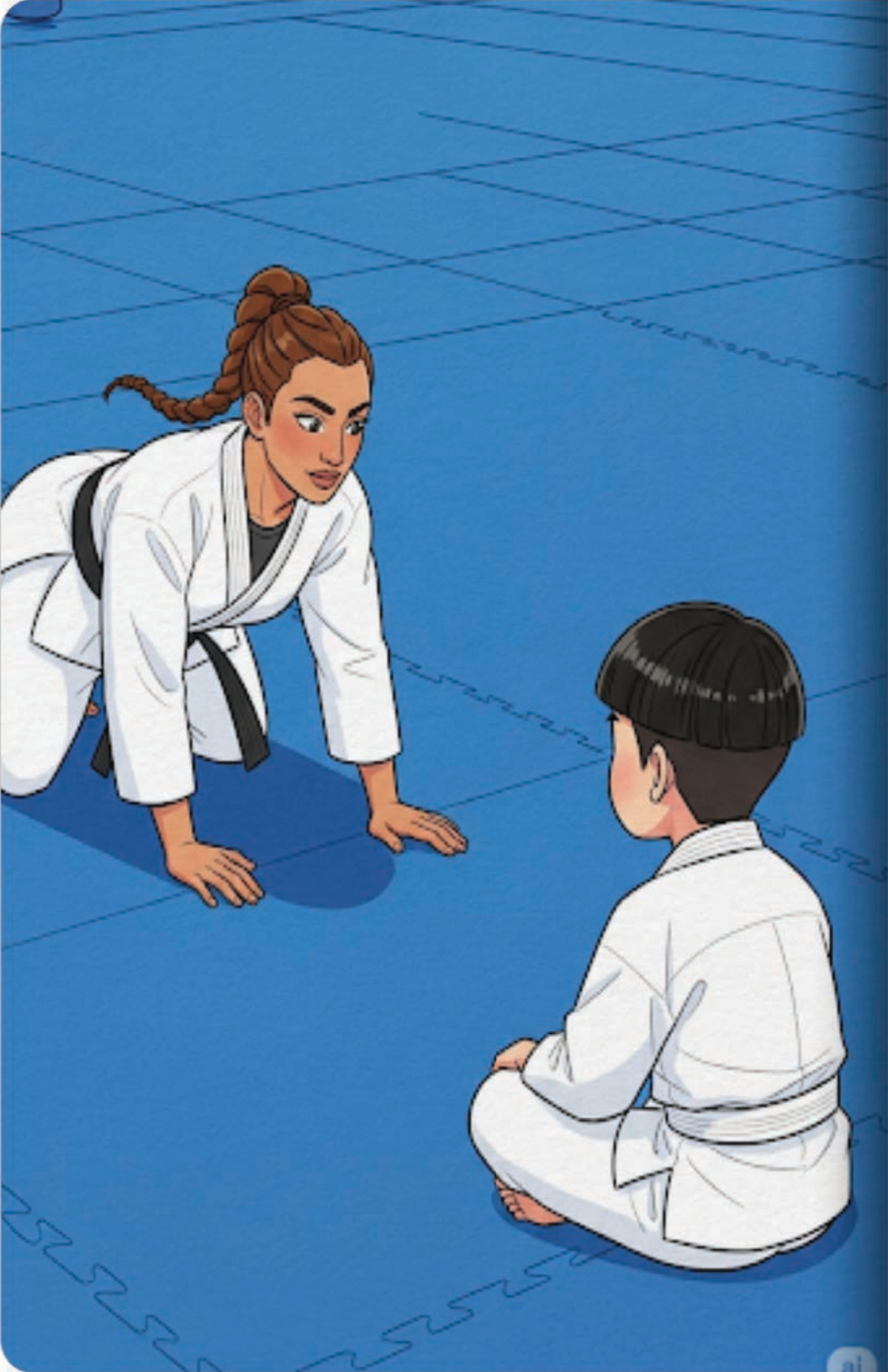
Coach Elara pointed to a row of cubbies. "Go ahead and change in the locker room, Kenji. Then come back here to get started." Kenji quickly changed into his crisp, white gi. He felt like a real martial artist now! He walked back toward the blue mats, still wearing his bright red sneakers. He was so eager to start that he almost stepped right onto the blue surface.



"Whoa, stop right there!" a voice called out. A boy about Kenji's age with a yellow stripe on his belt jogged over. He stopped at the very edge of the blue mat. "I'm Mica," the boy said with a friendly grin. "You're new, right? Rule number one: never, ever wear shoes on the mat. Not even for a second!" Kenji froze, his sneaker hovering just inches above the blue foam.



Kenji stepped back quickly. "Oh! Sorry, Mica. I didn't know." Mica sat down on the edge of the mat to talk. "It's okay! But think about it—shoes walk outside on the sidewalk, in the grass, and even in the restroom. If we wear them on the mat, all those germs and dirt get on the place where we put our faces and hands. We have to keep the mat 'sacred' and clean so nobody gets sick."



Kenji tucked his sneakers into a cubby and stepped onto the mat in his bare feet. It felt cool and firm. Coach Elara gathered the students in a circle. While she explained how to do a "shrimp" crawl, Kenji started to ask Mica a question about his yellow stripe. "Shhh," Mica whispered, pointing toward the coach. "When Coach Elara is talking, we listen with our eyes and our ears. It shows respect and keeps us safe."



After twenty minutes of jumping jacks and rolling, Coach Elara called out, "Water break! Two minutes!" Kenji was parched. He scrambled toward the edge of the mat, heading straight for the water fountain near the back of the gym. The floor between the mat and the fountain was made of cold, gray tiles. He was halfway there when he heard a whistle.



Mica was standing by the mat's edge, holding Kenji's flip-flops. "Kenji! Shoes!" he shouted. Kenji looked down at his bare feet on the tile. "But I'm not on the mat," Kenji said, confused. Mica shook his head. "That's the second part of the rule! If you walk barefoot on the gym floor, your feet pick up dirt. Then, when you step back on the mat, you bring that dirt with you. Always wear shoes the moment you step off the blue."



At the end of class, everyone lined up and bowed. Kenji felt tired but proud. He walked to the edge of the mat, stepped into his flip-flops, and turned to Mica. "Thanks for the help today, Mica. See you next time?" Mica smiled and bumped Kenji's fist. "Definitely. Great rolling, Kenji!" Kenji walked out the glass doors, knowing exactly how to keep his team safe and his gym clean.